

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Berlin and NATO — The Crystallization of the Cold War Alliance System

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the following three primary source excerpts and respond to the prompt below. Apply HIPP analysis to at least two documents and construct an argument.

The sources

Document A

President Harry S. Truman, Statement on the Berlin Airlift, July 19, 1948 — U.S. government document, available through the Harry S. Truman Presidential Library (National Archives)

“We are in Berlin as a result of our agreements with our Allies after the defeat of Germany... These agreements also gave us certain rights of access to Berlin. I want the record to be absolutely clear that abandonment of our position in Berlin would mean the loss of more than a city. It would be a blow to the entire structure of resistance to Soviet expansionism.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

North Atlantic Treaty, Preamble and Article 5, April 4, 1949 — multilateral treaty, available through the Avalon Project, Yale Law School

“The Parties... are determined to safeguard the freedom, common heritage and civilisation of their peoples, founded on the principles of democracy, individual liberty and the rule of law... The Parties agree that an armed attack against one or more of them in Europe or North America shall be considered an attack against them all.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document C

President John F. Kennedy, "Ich bin ein Berliner" speech, West Berlin, June 26, 1963 — U.S. government document, available through the John F. Kennedy Presidential Library (National Archives)

“There are many people in the world who really don't understand, or say they don't, what is the great issue between the free world and the Communist world. Let them come to Berlin. Freedom is indivisible, and when one man is enslaved, all are free. The wall is the most obvious and vivid demonstration of the failures of the Communist system.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using all three documents and your knowledge of the Berlin crises and NATO formation (US.62, US.59), construct an argument that evaluates Berlin's symbolic and strategic significance in the Cold War. Apply HIPP analysis to at least two documents and

1. why Berlin was the central flashpoint of the early Cold War
2. how the Berlin crises shaped NATO's development and the Western alliance's resolve; and
3. what the Berlin Wall reveals about the relative effectiveness of communist and capitalist systems as perceived by their own populations

Plan your answer

Your claim	

Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Precise arguable thesis on Berlin's symbolic/strategic significance. Full HIPP analysis on at least two documents (all four elements, historically accurate). Outside evidence (minimum 3 specific facts). Addresses all three prompt components. Synthesis demonstrates understanding of how Berlin functioned as both test case and showcase.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. Full HIPP on two documents (may miss one element). Two outside evidence points. Addresses two of three prompt components clearly.
4	Proficient. Arguable thesis. HIPP partially applied to two documents. One outside evidence fact. Addresses two prompt components.
3	Adequate. General thesis. Analyzes at least two documents without systematic HIPP. Some outside knowledge.
2	Developing. Basic claim. References documents, mostly summary. Minimal outside evidence.
1	Beginning. Attempts a response. Documents referenced without analysis.
0	No response or off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: Document A HIPP — Truman's 'structure of resistance' language as containment framework extended to Berlin; legal rights argument as foundation for airlift legitimacy. Document B HIPP — Article 5's collective defense principle as revolutionary shift in U.S. foreign policy away from isolationism; the specific reference to 'Europe or North America' as deliberately inclusive. Document C HIPP — Kennedy's use of the Wall as rhetorical evidence of comparative system failure; audience includes East Berliners watching from across the Wall. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: Berlin Blockade (June 1948–May 1949) logistics; 11-month airlift success; NATO founding (April 1949); Berlin Wall construction (August 13, 1961); 3.5 million East German refugees (1945–1961); Checkpoint Charlie crisis (Oct. 1961); Berlin as divided city until 1989 (US.70).

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.